Amtrak Rail Pass

This summer, I plan to use the Amtrak Rail Pass to travel for 1 month. This blog will contain my plans for the journey, and my thoughts on each day's experiences.
The following map gives an overview of the approximate Amtrak routes across the U.S. Chicago is the center of the rail network.

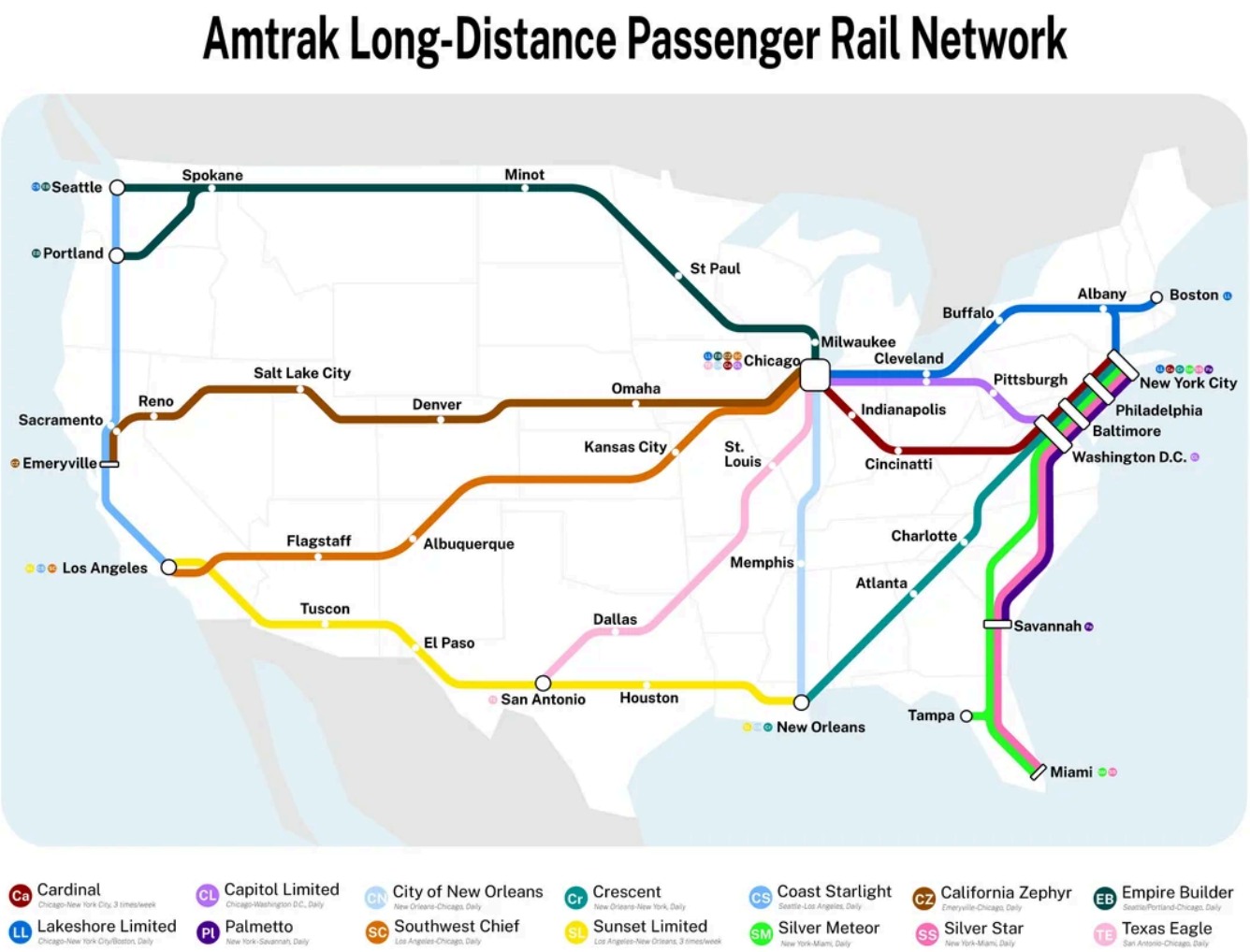

Figure 1: Amtrak Route Map [1]

Itinerary

Currently, the itinerary of cities is

- Marshall, Texas -> Chicago (Texas Eagle) April 25-26
- Chicago -> Boston (Lakeshore Limited) April 26-27
- Boston -> New York City (Lakeshore Limited) April 30
- New York City -> Philadelphia (Vermonter) May 5
- Philadelpha -> Washington D.C. (Northeast Regional) May 8
- Washington D.C. -> Chicago (Floridian) May 11th-May 12
- Chicago -> Seattle (Empire Builder) May 12-May 14
- Seattle -> Emeryville (Coast Starlight) May 17-May 18
- Emeryville -> Chicago (California Zephyr) May 20-22
- Chicago -> Dallas (Texas Eagle) May 23-May 24

Boston - April 27th-30th

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
Day 1 — Apr 28	9:00 AM	Boston Common	FREE	Start here

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
	Morning	Public Garden	FREE	Swan Boats seasonal
	Morning	Beacon Hill Friends House	FREE	Brief stop
	Mid-Morning	Freedom Trail (2.5 mi)	FREE	Follow red brick path
	Mid-Morning	Park Street Church	FREE	Along trail
	Mid-Morning	Granary Burying Ground	FREE	Along trail
	Mid-Morning	King’s Chapel	FREE	Along trail
	Lunch	Faneuil Hall & Quincy Market	FREE	Browse & eat
	Afternoon	Paul Revere House	$5.50	
	Afternoon	Old North Church	$5	
	Lunch/Dinner	Galleria Umberto	$8–$12	Cash only
	Evening	Rose Kennedy Greenway	FREE	Neighborhood stroll
	Evening	Beacon Hill	FREE	End near South Station
Day 2 – Apr 29	Morning	Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum	$15	2–3 hours
	Midday	Museum of Fine Arts	$30	
	Afternoon	Trinity Church	FREE	Back Bay, 30 min
	Afternoon	Boston Public Library	FREE	Back Bay, 30 min
	Afternoon	Copley Square	FREE	Walk around
Day 3 – Apr 30	Morning	Newbury Street	FREE	Shopping/dining
	Morning	Harvard Square	FREE	If not done Day 2
	Midday	Waterfront/Harbor Walk	FREE	Scenic walk
	Midday	Seaport District	FREE	Restaurants & browsing
	7:47 PM	**Depart South Station**	–	–

New York City - April 30th-May 5th

- Museum Mile free/cheap student picks: The Met (pay-what-you-wish, can pay $1 with ID), El Museo del Barrio (free), Museum of the City of New York (free) — skip the Neue Galerie ($25, no discount)

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
Apr 30	11:49 PM	Arrive Queens	–	Check in, rest
Day 1 – May 1 (Manhattan)	Morning	Times Square	FREE	Less crowded early
	Morning	New York Public Library	FREE	
	Mid-Morning	Grand Central Station	FREE	
	Mid-Morning	Rockefeller Center	FREE	Exterior
	Afternoon	AMNH	Pay-what-you-wish	Can pay $1 w/ student ID
	Afternoon	Central Park	FREE	Walk through after AMNH
	Evening	Greenwich Village	FREE	Dinner & wander
Day 2 – May 2 (Manhattan)	Morning	5th Avenue + St. Patrick’s Cathedral	FREE	Start midtown, walk north

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
	Mid-Morning	Museum Mile (82nd–105th St)	—	All on 5th Ave
	Mid-Morning	The Met	Pay-what-you-wish	Can pay $1 w/ student ID
	Mid-Morning	El Museo del Barrio	**FREE**	Students free
	Mid-Morning	Museum of the City of New York	**FREE**	Students free
	Afternoon	Guggenheim	**$18**	Student ID
	Evening ⭐	MoMA	**FREE**	Free every Fri 5:30–9pm
Day 3 — May 3 (Queens)	Morning	Flushing Chinatown	FREE	Best cheap food in NYC
	Afternoon	Flushing Meadows-Corona Park	FREE	USTA, Queens Museum nearby
	Evening	Jackson Heights	FREE	Little India — great cheap eats
Day 4 — May 4 (Brooklyn)	Morning	Brooklyn Botanic Garden	~$15	Free Tues & select Sat mornings
	Midday	Prospect Park	FREE	Adjacent to BBG
	Afternoon	DUMBO	FREE	Great Manhattan Bridge views
	Afternoon	Walk Brooklyn Bridge	FREE	Brooklyn→Manhattan side
	Evening	Little Italy	FREE	Dinner on the way back
Day 5 — May 5 (Queens AM)	Morning	Explore local Queens neighborhood	FREE	Easy since you're staying there
	Mid-Morning	Statue of Liberty — Battery Park or Staten Island Ferry	FREE	Ferry is free + closer views
	Afternoon	The Edge / Penn Station area	~$38 or FREE	Optional last splurge before departure
	6:49 PM	**Depart NYC**	—	

Philadelphia few additions worth knowing:

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
May 5	8:07 PM	Arrive Philadelphia	—	Grab food near hotel; Reading Terminal closes ~6pm
Day 1 — May 6 (Old City)	Morning	Liberty Bell	**FREE**	NPS; no tickets needed
	Morning	Independence Hall	**FREE**	Free timed-entry — book at recreation.gov in advance

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
	Mid-Morning	Free Quaker Meeting House	**FREE**	Steps from Independence Hall
	Mid-Morning	Arch Street Meeting House	Free/donation	Oldest continuously used meetinghouse in the US
	Mid-Morning	Elfreth’s Alley	**FREE**	Oldest residential street in the US; very photogenic
	Midday	Reading Terminal Market	FREE to enter	Lunch; $8–15 for a full meal
	Afternoon	Delaware River Waterfront	**FREE**	Penn’s Landing, scenic walk
	Evening	Old City murals / wander	**FREE**	Philly has some of the best street art in the US
Day 2 — May 7 (South Philly + Center City)	Morning	Italian Market	**FREE**	Oldest open-air market in the US; great cheap eats
	Mid-Morning	Magic Gardens	**~$10**	Student discount; Isaiah Zagar mosaic art on South Street
	Midday	South Street	**FREE**	Wander, lunch, shops
	Afternoon	Rittenhouse Square	**FREE**	Beautiful park, upscale neighborhood
	Afternoon	City Hall	**FREE**	Walk around; observation tower ~$8
	Evening	Fishtown	**FREE**	Hip neighborhood, great cheap dinner spots
Day 3 — May 8 (Parkway Morning)	Morning	Benjamin Franklin Parkway	**FREE**	Outdoor scenic boulevard
	Mid-Morning	Philadelphia Museum of Art	**~$14**	Student ID; Rocky steps are always free
	1:47 PM	**Depart Philadelphia**	—	

Washington D.C. - May 8th-May 11th

- Smithsonian Museums
- Baltimore

Seattle - May 14-May 17

San Francisco - May 18-May 20

Packing List

Essentials

- ☑ Hiking Bag
- ☑ Water Bottle
- ☑ Sleeping Bag
- ☐ Trackers
- ☐ Day Bag

Clothing

Essentials

- ☐ 3 Pants
- ☐ 1 Sweatpant
- ☐ 2 Undershirt
- ☐ 3 Athletic T-Shirts
- ☐ 1 Sweater
- ☐ 4 Socks
- ☐ 4 Underwear
- ☐ Shoes
- ☑ Windbreaker

Extra

- ☑ Emergency Poncho
- ☑ Umbrella
- ☐ Needle/Thread

Toiletries

- ☐ Towel
- ☐ Toothbrush/toothpaste
- ☐ Mouth Guard
- ☑ Deodorant
- ☐ Shampoo/soap (travel sizes)
- ☐ Hand sanitizer
- ☑ First Aid Kit
- ☑ Sunscreen
- ☐ TP
- ☑ First Aid Kit

Electronics

- ☐ Phone/Charger
- ☐ Laptop/Charger
- ☐ Battery Pack

Food

Grocery Items

- ☐ Granola

- ☐ Dried Fruit
- ☐ Bread
- ☐ Hard Cheese
- ☐ Nut Butter
- ☐ Dark Chocolate

Extra

- ☐ Spoon/Knife/Fork

Other

- ☑ Playing Cards
- ☐ Ziploc Bag
- ☐ Driver's License
- ☐ Pictures of Passport
- ☐ Credit/Debit Card
- ☐ Printed Tickets

Bibliography

[1] caliberal, "A map I made showing the Amtrak long-distance routes." 2023.